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California Legislature passes - $2.5 billion fire relief bill

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California lawmakers unanimously approved $2.5 billion to aid wildfire cleanup and recovery in the Los Angeles area Thursday morning just 10 days after Gov. Gavin Newsom called for it in a special session.

Newsom, who is in Southern California monitoring the response, wasexpected to sign the legislation by the afternoon, alongside legislative leaders.

"This is going to be a long journey that we're going to meet together, to stand with those communities every step of the way as they seek to rebuild," said Assembly Budget Chair Jesse Gabriel, D-San Fernando Valley.

Republican lawmakers in the Assembly tried unsuccessfully to add $1 billion in wildfire prevention funding, which was not included in the bills approved by lawmakers.

"Wildfire prevention is a glaring omission from the relief package being passed today," Assembly Republican Leader James Gallagher said in a statement after the vote. "We can't keep underfunding fire prevention and waiting to respond until after a disaster."

But lawmakers in both parties agreed that the aid package is just the beginning and signaled more work is needed throughout the year on wildfire management and rebuilding the economies of housing of communities hit by the fires.

"This is just step one," said Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, who introduced one of the bills.

"Whatever we do today, and from here on forward, we're going to need to do better," said Sen. Kelly Seyarto, a Republican from the Murrieta area and a retired firefighter.

They also warned that a warming planet is driving more extreme wildfires and other natural disasters in California and globally.

"The worst wildfires in the history of the state of California have all been the last 10 years. And why is that? It's because of climate change," said Assemblymember Al Muratsuchi, D-Torrance. "We need to keep the big picture in mind."

The $2.5 billion package is intended to expedite cleanup and home assessments, provide shelter for displaced residents and pay for other emergency response measures. It also requires the state to post monthly updates tracking the spending.

The state is expected to ask the federal government to be reimbursed for at least part of the payment.

How much money will flow back is not completely clear.

Former President Joe Biden pledged the federal government would reimburse the state for 100% of the recovery costs for the first 180 days of the emergency.

But newly sworn in President Donald Trump has clashed with Newsom over California's fire and water management policies. Trump has threatened to withhold wildfire disaster aid if the state does not make changes and Republican

members of Congress have suggested there might be conditions for future support.

Also on Thursday, Democratic senators passed bills that would provide $50 million to support the state Department of Justice in legal actions against the Trump administration as well as for organizations that provide legal services.

The Assembly could take up the measures as early as next week.

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